



Streak breaks: Neeraj Chopra's run of 26 top-two finishes ended at the World Championships 2025. REUTERS

years that the Tokyo Olympic champion had been bested by another Indian. (The last instance was at the 2017 World Championships, when Davinder Kang made the finals while Neeraj failed to advance from qualification.)

Remarkable as it was, Naval – who had stayed back in India with a liver ailment just weeks earlier – told *Sportstar* he was not fully satisfied.

“On the one hand, I’m happy that he got a Personal Best throw in such a major competition. But it feels incomplete. After the first throw (86.27m), I was expecting him to cross 90m. In the past, Sachin had been throwing really hard in his first attempt, but something always went wrong. At the National Games (where he won gold in February this year), he had thrown over 86m in his warm-up but twisted his ankle in his first throw. Then at the Neeraj Chopra Classic (in July), he nearly slipped again. At the World Championships, the plan was to go at only 80 per cent



Historic first: Sarvesh Kushare cleared a personal best of 2.28m to finish joint sixth in the men’s high jump final at the World Championships in Tokyo, becoming the first Indian to reach a Worlds final in the event. AP

in his first throw. So, after that went to 86m, I was confident a much bigger throw was coming. But luck was not on our side,” says Naval.

Bad luck came in the form of one of the sudden downpours that swept across Tokyo’s Olympic Stadium during the Championships. “When it rains, the Mondotrack runway becomes really slippery. It becomes really difficult to control your run-up. If it wasn’t for the rain, Sachin would have been standing on the podium,” he says.

Neeraj was another who might blame misfortune for his result. Having medalled at the last two World Championships, he seemed in good touch heading to Tokyo. He had crossed the 90m mark for the first time at the Doha Diamond League and sailed through qualification with his first throw. What was not known until after the final was that he had suffered a back injury just weeks before. Unable to train or even throw until the start of the competition,

Neeraj managed one big qualifying throw, but the final proved a step too far.

India’s contingent disappoints

Neeraj had entered the competition as India’s best medal hope, with Sachin seen as a dark horse. With both falling short of the podium, India finished outside the medals altogether. This stood in stark contrast to the overall diversity of the medal table – a record 53 different nations reached the podium at these Worlds, surpassing the previous record of 46 set at Osaka in 2007 and equalled in Budapest in 2023.

Beyond medals, India’s overall performance in Tokyo was notably weaker than at the 2023 Worlds. In Budapest, six Indian athletes reached finals, setting four Personal Bests, two National Records and one Continental Record. In Tokyo, only three athletes (high jumper Sarvesh Kushare, Neeraj and Sachin) made the finals, while just three (Sachin,